

A struggle to save the H.H. Richardson House

Group wants famous architect's former home to make endangered list

By Robert Campbell
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Every year, the National Trust for Historic Preservation in Washington issues a list of "America's 11 Most Endangered Historic Places."

The chosen 11 are historic sites that are in danger of being demolished, or otherwise lost. Last year's list included everything from a Civil War battlefield in West Virginia to a string of "Doo Wop" motels in New Jersey.

This year's list comes out in April or May. Massachusetts has a candidate.

A volunteer group, the "Committee to Save the H.H. Richardson House," has nominated a remarkable house at 25 Cottage St. in Brookline.

This was the home of Henry Hobson Richardson, the greatest

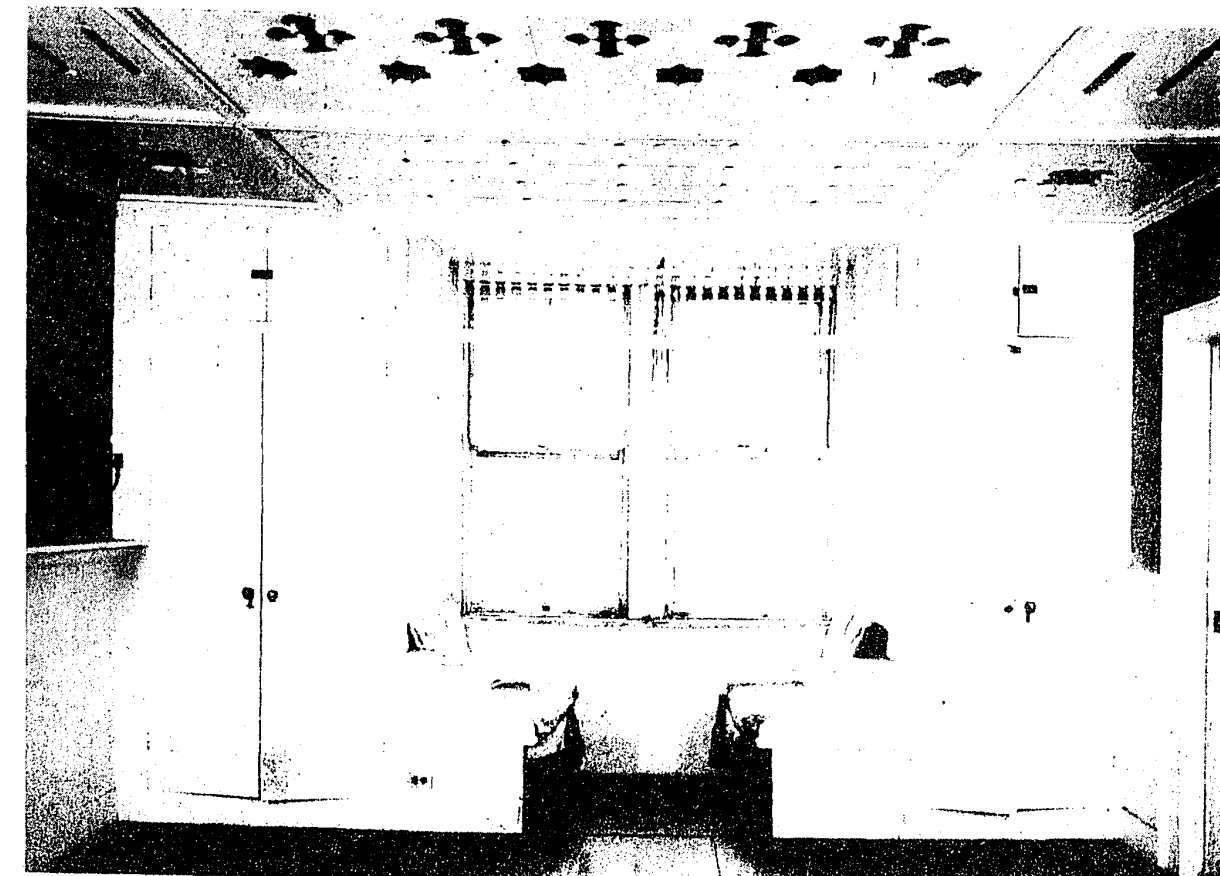
architect ever to practice in Boston. Richardson was the designer of Trinity Church in Copley Square and many other masterpieces across the country. He became so famous that a whole style of massive stone or brick architecture, usually with deep round arches, came to be called "Richardsonian Romanesque." His influence on other architects has been documented as far away as Scandinavia.

Richardson didn't design 25 Cottage. But he lived here for the whole of his productive career, from 1874 until he died in 1886 in his second-floor bedroom. He redesigned much of the interior and added new space for his architectural office and library.

The bedroom remains almost unchanged today. From its window, in the days before the trees had grown tall, Richardson could and did monitor the construction of Trinity. The bedroom walls are lined with cork, so the architect could pin up drawings to discuss with his clients or staff. (The staff included two young men named Stanford White and Charles McKim, who later became almost as celebrated as Richardson himself.)

Richardson designed the bedroom's Moorish-style ceiling tiles. Most movingly, he installed two metal rings, bolted into the bedroom wall, that he could grip to pull his enormous bulk out of bed in his later years, when he was plagued by Bright's disease.

Richardson's descendants lived here until 2000. The house is now owned by a couple who live next door, Fred and Caroline Hoppin. They bought it with the hope of saving it. They've spent almost \$2 million to date on the



PHOTOS BY DAVID BOHL/COURTESY OF HISTORIC NEW ENGLAND/SPNEA (ABOVE AND BELOW); ALLAN GALPER (BOTTOM)

Trinity Church designer Henry Hobson Richardson lived in this house on Cottage Street in Brookline from 1874 until he died in its second-floor bedroom (pictured above) in 1886. The room's walls are lined with cork, so he could pin up drawings. Below is a hallway in the house, built in the 18th century. The bottom photo shows the main view of the house's east front.

property, and they continue to bleed money for taxes and mortgage payments. They'd like to sell without taking a loss. If they can't, they'll have to let the house, which needs a lot of work, be demolished.

Lovers of the house believe its days are numbered in months, not years. The cost to buy and renovate the house is estimated at around \$5 million.

What the house needs now is a buyer who will love it, care for it, and fix it up. The buyer could be a wealthy individual or it could be an institution. It's been suggested, for example, that the property would make a good president's house for the head of a university or other institution.

To find a buyer, the house needs to get national attention. And the "Eleven Most Endangered" is the best way of getting it.

Richard Moe, chief of staff to Vice President Walter Mondale from 1977 to 1981, has long been the president of the National Trust. Moe has visited the house and he knows it well.

But will he put it on the list?

"It's a very significant house," Moe says by telephone from Washington. "There's a very compelling case here." In other words, he talks the vague but encouraging language one expects from Washington.

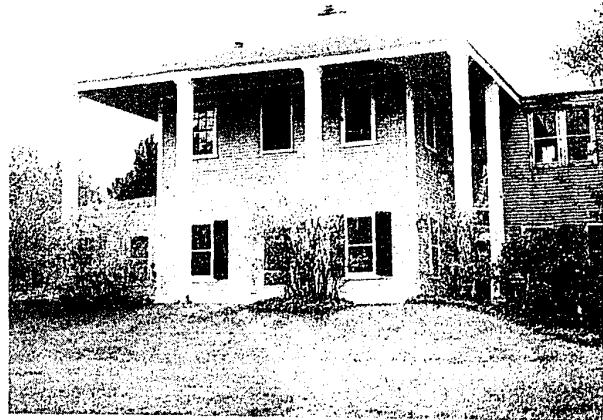
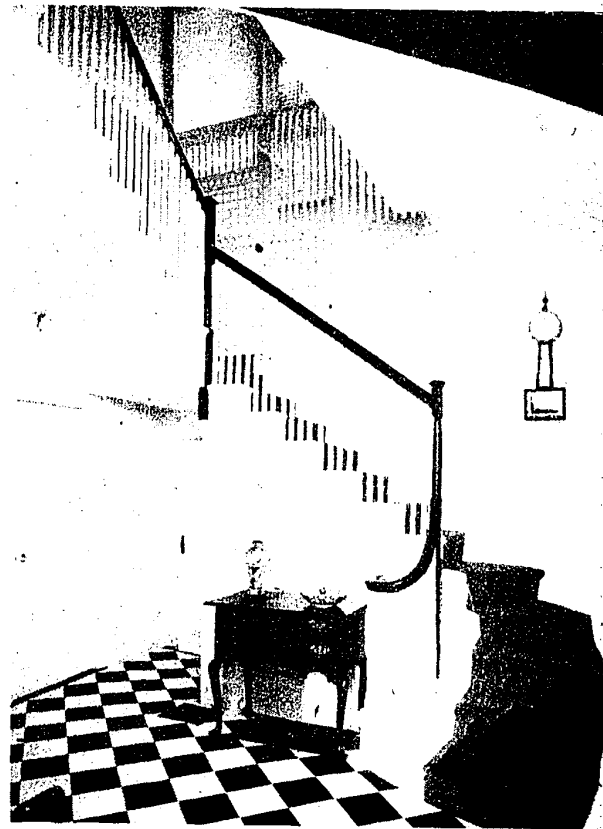
You can't blame him. The Endangered List is extremely competitive. All over the country, people are trying to get sites named to it. The Richardson House deserves to be on the 2007 list. But we'll have to see.

The entire preservation community here has long been on the case. Last fall, seven groups, including the local office of the National Trust, joined to hold a charrette — a term architects use to describe a period of intense activity. Teams of architects and others worked to explore options for the house. An engineering firm reported on its physical condition. The house, said this consultant, is "totally salvageable."

Even leaving Richardson out of the equation, the house is remarkable. It was built in the 18th century as a summer house for Boston's Samuel Gardner Perkins. It was added to several times, most notably with a tall porch that looks less like New England than like a planter's house in sunny Jamaica. And indeed historians call it "West Indian Style."

It stands in the Green Hill Historic District, an area of two dozen houses that also includes the estate of Frederick Law Olmsted, the great landscape architect who was sometimes Richardson's collaborator, and who often walked over for a chat and a drink.

We've lost too many houses



lately. Only last week a modernist masterpiece by architect Paul Rudolph bit the dust in Westport, Conn. A little earlier, we lost the landmark Rachel Raymond house in Belmont.

Architecture is a lot of things. One of those things is a memory bank. In places like the Richard-

son house, we deposit our cultural memories. If we can't save it, we don't really deserve to call ourselves civilized.

Robert Campbell is the Globe's architecture critic. He can be reached at camglobe@aol.com.

Reproduced with permission of the copyright owner. Further reproduction prohibited without permission.